2026-10-15 | VS&A Daily |

When damping tips a spinning spacecraft



Explorer 1’s unexpected wobble

The radio signal carried an uncomfortable clue. Explorer 1 had reached orbit, but its slender body was not keeping the intended steady, end-over-end-free spin. JPL’s later account describes a roughly 60° precession cone developing within about one orbit, inferred from variations in received signal strength [1].

The explanation challenged an instinct that still serves vibration engineers well on most days: dissipation should make motion settle down. Here, flexible antennas dissipated energy while the unwanted attitude motion grew. Nothing was supplying mysterious negative damping. The system was moving toward a lower-energy rotation.

Today’s objective: use an energy–angular-momentum argument to distinguish a decaying structural vibration from a stable spacecraft attitude—and recognize when a damping change can undermine the intended spin.

Historical photograph: Pickering, Van Allen and von Braun with an Explorer 1 model after the January 31, 1958 launch. Its slender geometry is central to this lesson. Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech. Image source [3].

This was an attitude-dynamics surprise, not the loss of the mission. Explorer 1 became the first successful U.S. satellite and supplied evidence of Earth’s trapped radiation. That scientific achievement should not be confused with whether its planned rotational behavior was achieved [4].

The lesson is especially useful at the boundary between VS&A and flight dynamics. A positive structural loss factor answers a local question about energy dissipated during deformation. Whether that loss improves the vehicle’s motion requires a second question: which rotational state has the least energy under the system’s constraints?

Reading time: approximately 10 minutes, including equations and figures.

A spinning rod has two very different “stable” states

For a torque-free rigid body, rotation about either the smallest or largest principal moment is stable to small perturbations; the intermediate-axis rotation is not. Explorer 1 was intended to spin about its minimum-inertia axis, along its length. Its four flexible whip antennas made the rigid-body idealization incomplete [2].

Now separate two balances that are easily conflated. Internal forces and moments can exchange momentum between the main body and appendages, but do not change the total angular momentum of an isolated system. Internal friction can nevertheless turn mechanical energy into heat. In an inertial frame, with external torque neglected:

$$\frac{d\mathbf{H}}{dt} = \mathbf{0}, \qquad \frac{dE_{\text{mech}}}{dt} = -P_{\text{loss}} \leq 0$$

H is total angular momentum [N·m·s], E_{mech} is rotational plus elastic mechanical energy [J], and P_{loss} is dissipated power [W]. Heat is not disappearing from the energy balance; it is leaving the mechanical-energy account.

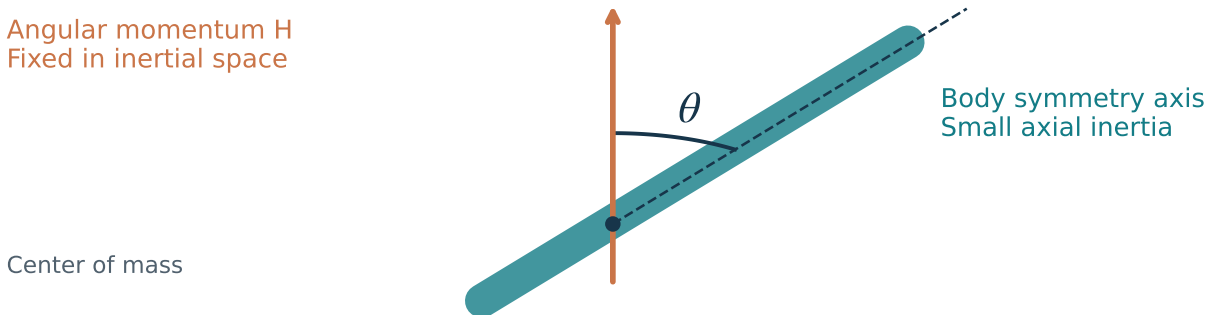


Figure 1. Original conceptual diagram, not flight attitude data. θ is the angle between the body symmetry axis and H; it is not generally the angle between angular velocity and H.

To expose the geometry, approximate the vehicle as an axisymmetric main body with axial moment I_a and equal transverse moments I_t, with $I_a < I_t$. Treat appendage deformation as a weak energy sink, neglecting its instantaneous contribution to momentum and inertia. Resolve the fixed momentum into body-axis components:

$$H_a = H\cos\theta, \qquad H_t = H\sin\theta$$

For each principal component, angular velocity equals momentum divided by inertia. The transverse component can therefore carry a given share of H with less energy than the axial component. This is the opening through which a perfectly ordinary dissipative mechanism can drive an apparently extraordinary attitude change.

The energy goes down as the cone opens

Using rotational energy as one-half the sum of momentum times angular velocity gives our reduced model:

$$T(\theta) = \frac{H^2}{2}\left(\frac{\cos^2\theta}{I_a} + \frac{\sin^2\theta}{I_t}\right)$$

Here T is the main-body rotational energy, approximately E_{mech} when the appendage's stored energy is small. At θ = 0°, the body spins along its length. At θ = 90°, that long axis lies perpendicular to H and the body rotates about a transverse principal axis. "Tumbling" in this limiting case need not mean chaotic motion.

Take deliberately illustrative values: I_a = 0.10 kg·m², I_t = 1.00 kg·m² and H = 1.00 N·m·s. These are not Explorer 1 mass properties. Substituting them gives a simple energy landscape:

$$T(\theta) = (5.00\cos^2\theta + 0.50\sin^2\theta)\,\mathrm{J}$$

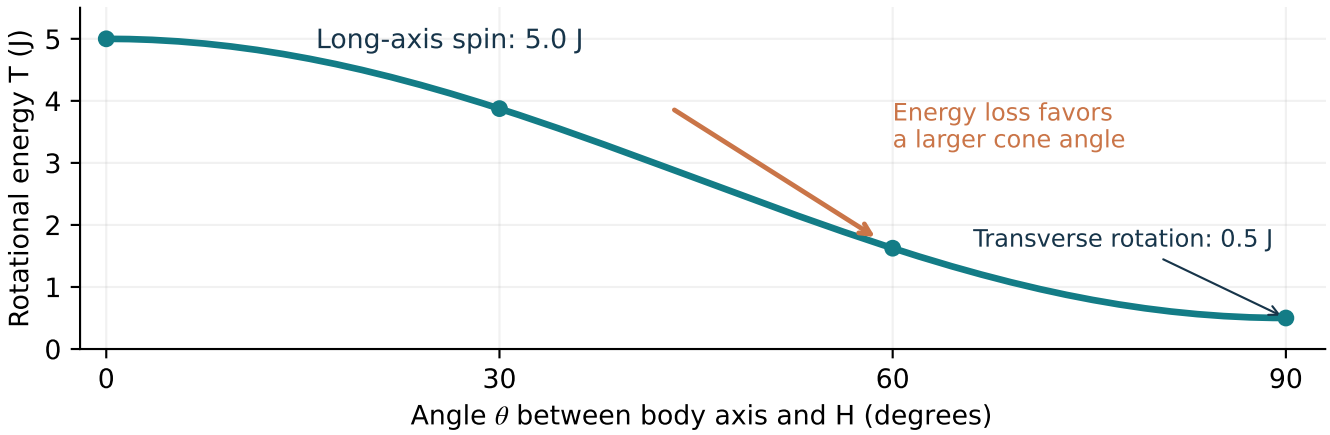


Figure 2. Original calculation for the stated idealized inertias and momentum. This is energy versus angle—not angle versus time, a measured trajectory or an Explorer 1 reconstruction.

At 30°, energy is 3.875 J; at 60°, it is 1.625 J. The limiting long-axis and transverse states differ by 4.50 J, even though both carry exactly the same angular momentum. The corresponding pure-rotation speeds are 10.0 and 1.0 rad/s. Energy loss has changed both the orientation of rotation in the body and the speed, without removing H.

That is the counterintuitive result in ordinary language: the vehicle can make its attitude error larger while making its mechanical-energy account smaller. Dissipation does not promise to preserve whichever orientation the designer originally preferred.

An energy argument is not a flight clock

The curve tells us which way energy decreases. It does not tell us how fast the spacecraft gets there. Differentiating the reduced expression gives:

$$\frac{dT}{d\theta} = H^2 \sin\theta\cos\theta\left(\frac{1}{I_t} - \frac{1}{I_a}\right)$$

Between 0° and 90°, the slope is negative for a slender body. If the weak-loss approximation is valid and P_{loss} is known as a function of state, the secular angle rate follows from the energy balance:

$$\dot{\theta} = -\frac{P_{\text{loss}}}{dT/d\theta}$$

For a numerical check only, suppose the average loss at 30° is 0.010 W. The slope there is −3.897 J/rad, giving a local angle-growth rate of 0.00257 rad/s, or 0.147°/s. This is not a predicted flight growth rate. The assumed power is invented for the example, and holding it constant near either endpoint would make this formula misleading because the slope tends to zero.

An exactly unperturbed principal-axis spin has no wobble-driven cyclic deformation to dissipate. Real perturbations activate the coupling; the resulting antenna motion, loss mechanism and rotational state determine the power. A positive material damping coefficient alone is not enough to supply that function. Nor does doubling a modal damping input necessarily double the growth rate: deformation amplitudes can change too.

The historical evidence is more specific than the energy sketch. Likins’s JPL report attributes Explorer 1’s behavior to dissipation in the whip antennas. It records that removing those whips for Explorer III greatly slowed the attitude drift, rather than eliminating all drift. It also describes analyses using measured antenna damping and identifies resonance effects as important [1]. That supports the mechanism; it does not authorize inventing a detailed time history from the simple curve above.

The approximation also has a boundary. Strong elastic–rotational coupling requires the appendages’ momentum and strain energy explicitly. Large deformation changes the inertia tensor. External torques break fixed-H motion. Wheels, moving masses, fluids and active control introduce additional states or exchanges. A whole-vehicle stability model must include the mechanisms that actually exist, not merely append a damping percentage to rigid Euler equations.

Ask where the dissipated energy takes the vehicle

For a review of a spinning stage or spacecraft, start with the inertia ordering in each relevant configuration. Deployment, propellant consumption and attached hardware can change it. Then ask whether the desired rotation is an energy minimum at the applicable momentum constraint. A structurally quiet appendage is not, by itself, evidence of a stable pointing state.

This suggests a practical verification strategy: perturb the coupled model away from nominal spin, monitor both attitude error and mechanical energy, and check the angular-momentum residual. If a torque-free simulation loses substantial H merely because damping was enabled, investigate the formulation before trusting the apparent stabilization. Use loss data at representative preload, temperature and amplitude; a ground fixture may supply reactions absent in free flight.

Finally, judge growth against the required operating interval and pointing tolerance, not simply a label of stable or unstable. A slow drift may still defeat a long observation, while a short spin phase may require a different mitigation. Changes to inertia, appendage dynamics or active control should be evaluated as system trades. These are engineering implications of the balances here, not newly asserted flight requirements.

Three takeaways

1. Internal damping can reduce energy without reducing total angular momentum.
2. For the slender-body model, lower energy means a larger cone angle toward transverse rotation.
3. The energy landscape establishes a tendency; credible rates require the actual coupled deformation and loss mechanisms.

Reflection. If the symmetry-axis inertia were the largest instead of the smallest, would this same energy argument favor increasing θ?
Answer. No. The slope changes sign. Loss then favors decreasing θ toward symmetry-axis rotation, within the same passive, fixed-inertia, torque-free assumptions.

Sources, scope and visual credits

[1] P. W. Likins, Effects of Energy Dissipation on the Free Body Motions of Spacecraft, JPL Technical Report 32-860, July 1, 1966. Sections II–IV and Appendix A, especially printed pp. 17, 19 and 47–48. Primary technical report.

[2] NASA, Effects of Structural Flexibility on Spacecraft Control Systems, NASA SP-8016, April 1969, §2.1.1, pp. 4–5. The foreword identifies this as design guidance, not a NASA requirement unless incorporated into project specifications. Design monograph.

[3] NASA/JPL-Caltech, Explorer 1 Team: A Successful Launch, historical photo of the February 1, 1958 news conference; NASA image page updated February 5, 2026. Photograph and credit.

[4] NASA Science, About Explorer 1, accessed October 15, 2026. Mission history. Figures 1–2 are original; all numerical calculations are illustrative, not measured flight data.